

▷ MAN-MADE HILL

One of the largest artificial mounds in Europe, Silbury Hill dates from around 2400 BCE. It is composed of clay and chalk and apparently contains no burial, which makes its purpose something of a mystery.



Timber

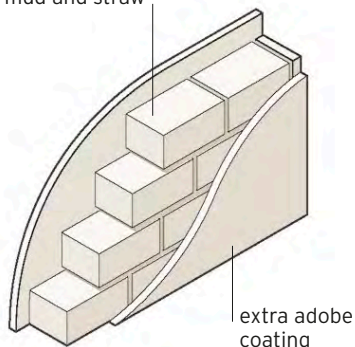
There is archaeological evidence that wood was used to build dwellings in Europe as early as 6000 or 5000 BCE. Numerous examples of longhouses dating from this time have been found, particularly in the region of Transdanubia, comprising northwestern Hungary, northern Austria, and southern Germany. These long, rectangular, single-room structures with oak posts supporting the roof are thought to have provided living quarters for up to 20–30 people, with multiple longhouses forming villages. Later, the discovery of metals such as bronze and steel, which could be fashioned into tools for cutting and shaping, advanced the ways in which wood could be used in construction.

The ancient Egyptians, Greeks, and Romans all made use of cut and carved timber, particularly in roof construction. It was the Romans who developed timber framing—the construction of wooden skeletons to support a building. This technique reached its peak during the Middle Ages, when carpenters created magnificently elaborate, ingenious, and frequently beautiful arrangements of timber

to support the roofs of halls, churches, and cathedrals. These include the hammer-beam roof of Westminster Hall in London, which is the largest medieval timber roof in northern Europe. Scandinavia had its own spectacular take on timber construction in the form of tumbling stave churches. Around the same time, the Chinese were constructing timber buildings of great complexity and refinement, exemplified by the Pagoda of Fogong Temple, built in 1056 and reaching over 220 ft (67 m) high, without a single nail, screw, or bolt.

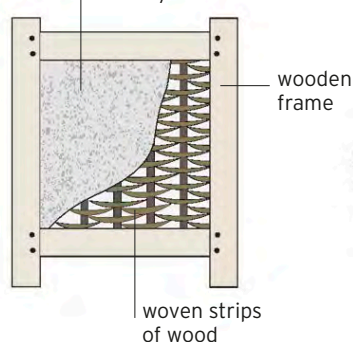
Timber continues to be used in construction because it is durable, often widely available, and renewable, and relatively little energy is needed to turn trees into usable timber. Architects are experimenting with new ways of using timber, exploiting its light weight and flexibility, including, most ambitiously, wooden skyscrapers, or “plyscrapers.”

adobe bricks made of mud and straw



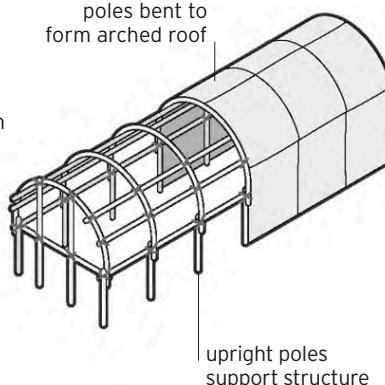
ADOBE

daubed covering of sticky mud



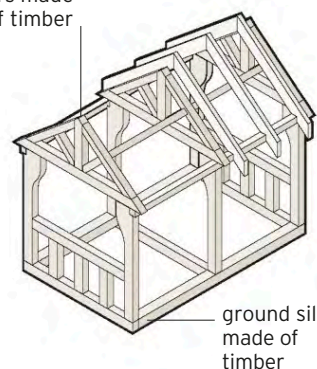
WATTLE-AND-DAUB

poles bent to form arched roof



LONGHOUSE

rafters made of timber



TIMBER-FRAME



△ EARLY ADOBE CONSTRUCTION

Mud mixed with straw (adobe) is compressed into molds and baked dry to form regular-sized bricks. Once laid, the bricks are faced with an additional coating of adobe, as seen above in Taos Pueblo, New Mexico.



△ WATTLE-AND-DAUB CONSTRUCTION

In this age-old construction technique, a woven lattice of wooden strips or branches (wattle), held between upright stakes, is daubed with a mixture of sticky mud and straw. This Tudor-style house in England employs this technique.



△ LONGHOUSE CONSTRUCTION

Ancient longhouses survived into the 19th century in North America, built and inhabited by the native tribes—notably the Iroquois of the northeastern US. This longhouse at the Ganondagan State Historic Site, New York, is one such example.



△ TIMBER-FRAME CONSTRUCTION

In parts of the world with a plentiful supply of wood, timber-framing became the most common form of construction because of its cheapness and versatility. The Paul Revere House in Boston is famous for its timber construction.